

MOLINA HEALTHCARE OF NEW JERSEY

Clinical Policy: Knee Arthroscopy with Partial Meniscectomy

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1. SCOPE

This policy applies to Molina Healthcare of New Jersey Medicaid managed care members seeking prior authorization for knee arthroscopy with partial meniscectomy (CPT 29881). Coverage is limited to members who meet all medical necessity criteria defined herein.

Applicable CPT codes: 29881 (Arthroscopy, knee, surgical; with meniscectomy (medial OR lateral, including any meniscal shaving)).

Applicable ICD-10 patterns: M23.2* (Derangement of meniscus due to old tear or injury).

Lines of business: Medicaid managed care.

States: NJ.

2. COVERAGE POLICY — MEDICAL NECESSITY CRITERIA

Authorization is approved when ALL of the following criteria are met:

2.1 AGE

Patient is 18 years of age or older.

2.2 DIAGNOSIS

Diagnosis of derangement of meniscus (ICD-10 M23.2*) confirmed by clinical evaluation.

2.3 FUNCTIONAL LIMITATION

Functional limitation documented, including but not limited to inability to perform activities of daily living due to knee instability or pain.

2.4 IMAGING OR EXAMINATION (ONE OF THE FOLLOWING)

At least one of the following must be present:

- (a) MRI demonstrating meniscal tear or meniscal pathology
- (b) Clinical examination findings consistent with meniscal tear, including positive provocative tests such as McMurray test or Thessaly test

2.5 FAILED CONSERVATIVE THERAPY

All of the following must be documented:

- (a) NSAID Trial:
 - Trial of non-steroidal anti-inflammatory drug (NSAID) therapy for a minimum of 4 weeks.
- (b) Physical Therapy (ONE OF THE FOLLOWING):
 - completion of a minimum of 6 physical therapy sessions directed at the affected knee
 - OR
 - documented contraindication to physical therapy

3. EXCLUSIONS

This policy does not cover the procedure when:

3.1 ACUTE EMERGENT

The condition is an acute traumatic tear requiring emergent surgical intervention (defined as injury within 72 hours requiring immediate surgical stabilization). Such cases must be managed through the emergency care pathway.

3.2 NON-MENISCAL PATHOLOGY

The primary indication is non-meniscal pathology (e.g., isolated chondral defect, ligamentous injury without meniscal involvement).

4. AUTHORIZATION

Submit PA request via standard payer portal with supporting clinical documentation including imaging reports, PT records, and medication history.
